

LIVING IN THE UNITED STATES LIKE A STUDENT

Overseas living makes so much sense, why would you ever want to stay in the United States? For one thing, you could have an ailing parent or friend who needs your attention. Or interests could keep you in the United States. You could want to study the history of the American Civil War, for example, or follow a college football team around the country. But I suspect most who choose to stay in the United States do so because they're reluctant to give up the American way of life. As a friend puts it, "When you leave the United States, you're camping out."

But even if you insist on staying in the United States, you can retire on a bare-bones \$743 a month. That amount of money buys less in high-cost America than in the Third World. Retire on \$743 in the United States and you have to make sacrifices. But if you're willing to share a house with others—I call it living in the United States like a student—you can probably swing it.

Most of us have fond memories of early adult life. We owned nothing and had few responsibilities. We lived cheaply in college dorms or small apartments. We built bookcases out of bricks and boards. We decorated with posters and cascading spider plants. We built huge desks by putting a door blank on sawhorses. We sat in the last row of theaters, visited museums on the free nights, and bought bleacher seats at baseball games. We did some of the things we now laugh at in *Animal House*, *Porky's*, and *Police Academy*.

Somewhere along the way we outgrew the student life. We got married or moved in with a partner, bought a home of our own, and started driving newer cars. We had children, dressed more carefully, and bought life insurance. But with each of these steps toward a better life we gave up something. Falling in love and getting married is great, but it usually means fewer friends will hang around. A home of our own serves as a fuzzy blanket and helps us grow up. But it also forces us to sand and paint walls, pull weeds, and sweep driveways.